

have such a—well, a lack of self-control—that they cannot pass by anything they don’t already have. It’s almost an obsession. Often it’s not even for themselves. They will even buy gifts for other people and charge them on their credit cards.”

Andrea thought about the watch she had bought Bill. She had bought him another one two weeks after they returned home. Bill had protested, but she’d convinced him to keep it.

Mike continued, “We all like to buy things, and we can all indulge, given the opportunity and the resources. But some people are what I would call shop-a-holics. They feel best when they’re buying something, even if they know they can’t afford it.”

Andrea realized that much of what the coach was saying did apply to her. She never had splurged very much, but she hadn’t had the opportunity until she had her mother’s credit card. Then it became a need that she had to satisfy. She had felt the same way about getting married that weekend. She didn’t think she was going to lose Bill, but she wasn’t willing to take the chance.

“Does that mean I should never handle the money again?” Andrea asked dejectedly.

“Not at all. It just means that you need to realize that Bill is in your life to offset your imbalances, just as you are to offset his. When you recognize what those imbalances are and learn to communicate about them openly, you’ll be further along than 90 percent of couples today. I’ll give you some homework to do together to help you better understand God’s plan for your marriage and your finances.

“In the meantime we need to deal with the immediate problem—these debts. I notice in your list of assets that you own two cars. Is that right?”

“Right,” Bill said. “Andrea’s and mine.”

“How much do you think they’re worth?”

“I would say mine is worth close to two thousand at best, and Andrea’s a little less,” Bill replied.